

Religion, and Kissing

By Lucia Lorenz

I walked down the hallway past the blue lockers and found Kristina leaning against the wall right outside the classroom, waiting for me. She wore the same plaid skirt I did, navy, white, and black, and a crisp white polo with our school's insignia stitched on the chest. I opted for a navy blue polo.

She pushes off the wall when she spots me and smiles. "David and Caleb asked if we wanted to sit with them." My stomach twisted. "Do you wanna?"

"Yeah, sure, we can sit with them, I don't care." I do care. I *so* do care. But I sweep it into the corner of my mind and try to pretend I don't.

I follow behind Kristina as she turns into the room. The desks are grouped into fours, and in the back corner, we spot David and Caleb laughing at each other. Kristina slides into the seat in front of David, and I take the one across from Caleb. My chair scrapes a little too loudly as I sit. I keep my eyes down, refusing to make eye contact, and busy myself with unpacking my things one by one, slower than necessary.

"We should hang out at Spring Field again. Playing that drinking game was so fun last weekend." David said, leaning back and grinning, "What was the game called again? You know, the one where if you don't answer, you have to drink. Lucy, what did you call it?" Both boys were wearing a white button-down shirt with a navy blue and red tie. Although David must have decided at some point during the day that it would look better wrapped around his head like a belt.

"Truth or truth," I replied as I still pretended to organize my folder, and pulled out my homework to be collected.

"Yeah! Yeah exactly! Except this time, we should just play truth or dare! And if you don't do the dare, then you drink as well." David explained, wiggling his eyebrows for emphasis.

"Okay, fine, but if we do, you boys have to bring the alcohol this time. Us girls did it last time." I glance up at Kristina and smile in gratitude. She knew how stressful it had been for me to sneak that bottle of Pinnacle from the liquor cabinet.

I'd almost gotten caught when I knocked over the statue of Mary. Looking back, I think my dad might've started to catch on because why was that statue right in front of the liquor, practically guarding it anyway? When he asked why I'd knocked it over, I just said I wanted a closer look at the statue and couldn't see from up there on the cabinet.

Whether he believed me or not, he didn't push it. Honestly, the guilt was punishment enough. Maybe that was his goal all along. I am not sure. Either way, I wasn't planning to risk it again anytime soon. Especially since, after we hung out, there was still half the bottle left, so I just filled it with water back to where it had been.

"I don't know about alcohol, but I can definitely get some weed from my brother, if we want to do that?" I look over at David and his ridiculous tie headband.

I've never had weed before. The thought, honestly, scares me. I've been around alcohol my whole life, at home, church, and with family; it was always there. But weed? Smoking? I have never seen it done in person. I wouldn't even know how. Like, do I breathe it in? Hold it? Let it out? What if I cough? No. I'd look stupid, and that scares me more than getting high.

"I can bring some alcohol."

I finally looked at him. God, his hair is always perfect. It is the color of summer, like a golden beach at sunset. His mom's a hairdresser, which might honestly be the second most attractive thing about him. Not too long, not too short, just the right kind of waves that curl up at his collar. I tell myself it's just her skill I admire. She's just a really, really good hairdresser. Nothing more.

Breaking the moment, Mrs. Dahl's voice cuts across the chatter, "Alright, everyone, bring your homework up to my desk and then go get a bible from the shelves and open it up to today's Gospel."

"I got it, guys!" David jumps up with all of our homework and heads to the desk, already returning juggling bibles for the group.

Religion was never my least favorite class. It felt more like English, with a focus on reading, writing, and discussing stories. Plus, Mrs. Dahl was kind, the kind of teacher who'd give you an extension before you even asked.

In eighth grade, we all had one major project in religion class, which involved spending the year studying the Passion stories from the four Gospels and, by spring, putting on a play about Jesus' death. So lately we'd been comparing how each writer described the crucifixion. Mark said Jesus cried out before he died. Luke said he went quietly. I was scribbling in my notebook about how Luke probably did not want others to see him in pain because he was so close to Jesus, while Mark's version seemed more realistic.

"I think I am going to be Jesus." David closes his notebook, done with the assignment. Caleb snorted.

Kristina raises an eyebrow at him. "You know the whole grade has to vote on that, right?"

"I know. Why wouldn't they pick me? I am very holy." He said while leaning back in his chair and balancing on two legs.

"Right." She mutters.

"Okay, who would you be then?" He teases.

Kristina shrugs. "I don't know, I haven't even thought about that." She closes her notebook and pushes it to the side. "Maybe Veronica. She's sassy when she shoves the guard to get to Jesus."

"You're right, she was probably a baddie."

"Gross," I said, rolling my eyes at David for sexualizing the idea of Veronica.

"Whatever. Are you guys done now? Truth or dare, Kristina?"

I side-eyed Kristina, knowing she would not resist responding.

"Truth."

"Okay, hmm... Kiss, Marry, Kill. Fred, Leo, or Ryan."

I finish writing my sentence and watch as Kristina thinks it over.

“Kiss Ryan, Marry Fred, and Kill Leo.” I secretly admire Kristina for always seeming to answer these questions so calmly. If it were me, I’d probably stammer and blurt something dumb.

“Yo, don’t do my boy Leo like that, he’s chill.” David shakes his head in disbelief.

“Oh, shush, if you didn’t want me to choose, you should not have given me that question. Now it’s my turn. Caleb, truth or dare.”

“Truth.” Caleb sits there with his head resting on his hand, watching Kristina and David’s whole interaction. Looking highly entertained by their bickering.

“Do you like anyone?”

“Yes.” My heart jumped so high it felt lodged in my throat. I stared at my notebook, rereading sentences I had already written. Trying to will my ears to pick up any voice or name that he might say.

Kristina giggles. “Who?”

“That wasn’t the question,” Caleb said smoothly, dodging.

David groans. “This is lame. No one is picking dare. Caleb do me, I want to do dare.”

“Ok, I dare you to hug Kristina.”

David turns to Kristina, a grin curling up his lips.

Kristina makes a face of disgust at David. “Gross, do I have to?”

“It is the dare,” David said, looking practically giddy. I couldn’t tell if he was more excited to annoy her or actually hug her.

“Fine,” She turns around, making sure Mrs. Dahl is not looking. Kristina stood to hug David, the chair legs screeching against the floor, making me wince. I was sure Mrs. Dahl would notice, but she kept calmly writing something at her desk. David quickly pushes his chair back, and he opens his arms wide in a comical way. I can’t help the giggle that escapes my lips at his obvious excitement and Kristina’s clear disinterest. She rolls her eyes, gives him a quick one-armed hug, then pulls back fast. “There. Done.” She walks back around to her seat.

“That’s all I get?” David says, clutching a hand to his chest mockingly.

“That’s all you ever will get, David.”

“Fine, Truth or Dare, Lucy?” He says, turning to me.

“Dare, I guess.”

A maniacal smirk tugs at the corner of David’s mouth. “I dare you to kiss Caleb.”

I feel like I’m about to throw up my own heart.

“Huh,” I can’t tell if I said that, or Kristina did.

“I dare you to kiss Caleb,” David repeats.

“How is she supposed to do that? As soon as Mrs. Dahl sees us, we are going to be sent out into the hall.” Kristina says, looking at David like he’s the dumbest person on the planet.

How *am* I supposed to do that? I am going to need an extremely detailed answer. I’ve never even kissed anyone before, so how do I just kiss Caleb? Especially Caleb, the boy I’ve had the biggest crush on since first grade, the one I used to play hockey with, who argued with me

about who was the best team, whose favorite color is purple. I feel a strange heat creeping up my neck. And I now think I'm going to throw up something purple.

How do I press my lips to his without it being weird or awkward? I hate feeling awkward. I'd rather my first kiss be with someone I don't care about so I can practice, and then kiss Caleb later. He can't be the first; it's too embarrassing.

"They could go in the closet. No one will know." David says. I glance at him, but I've perfected my mask of indifference since the first day of middle school. If I show that I care, I'll be teased and ridiculed. Which leaves me with one option, I have to kiss him. No choice. If I say no, I won't hear the end of it. Maybe I'll even be uninvited this weekend if I refuse.

I look over at Caleb. He's staring at me in a way I can't decipher. What if he doesn't want to do this? That might give me an out, but the thought of him saying no makes my stomach twist in a whole new way.

"Do you want to?" I ask him, pretending not to notice Kristina shooting me daggers from the back.

Caleb lifts one of his shoulders. "I don't care."

Okay. I don't like that response either, but I guess if he doesn't care, this won't be a huge deal. I just have to act like I don't care either. None of them knows this is my first kiss. They never have to. My hands feel clammy. Yeah, I've kissed many people before. I can do this. I just can't let it be embarrassing. It has to be perfect, or good enough that Caleb wants to do it again. One day, maybe. Yeah, no pressure.

"Ok, so how do we get into the closet without Mrs.Dahl noticing?" Caleb asks, completely unfazed by the idea of kissing me. I guess on the outside, I seem calm too, but inside, I can barely breathe.

"You guys could pretend to put the Bibles back and then slip into the closet, since they're close to each other," Kristina says, like she's done this before.

"Alright, I'll go first. Lucy, you follow a couple of seconds later, so it's not obvious we're up to something."

I nod. "Ok, yeah, I can do that." At least that's what I tell myself.

I watch Caleb get up with his Bible in the smoothest way possible. He walks over to the shelves, slides it in perfectly, and disappears into the closet without even glancing to see if Mrs. Dahl is watching. How does he even do that? Why does he look good at everything he does?

This is all happening too fast.

"Your turn," David says.

I get up, wrap my arms around my bible, and walk to the shelves. No spots left at eye level. I glance at the top shelf and find a slot between the books. I start sliding it in slowly, almost knocking the whole thing over. My heart hammers in my chest.

BANG!

"You ok back there, Lucy?" I spin around, mortified.

"Yeah, Mrs.Dahl. I just knocked some books down, all good." I scoop up the fallen books and slide them back into place. I can hear giggling from the table, Kristina and David. Don't look

back. Don't look back. My face is already bright red from the heat of embarrassment coursing through me.

Once I quickly get all the Bibles back on the shelf, I glance over my shoulder to make sure Mrs. Dahl isn't looking.

I slip around the corner of the closet and find Caleb standing there, awkwardly shifting from foot to foot, looking around. He turns and looks down at me.

"What happened?" Caleb asks, most definitely seeing the redness on my face.

I blow out a frustrated breath. "I knocked almost all of the Bibles off the shelf and everyone saw." I shake my head, but then look up and see him trying to hold in a laugh. Which ultimately makes me smile and start to giggle at myself. "I just can't believe I did that. Who does that, especially while trying to be quiet?"

"It is ok, it happens." He shrugs his shoulders.

We both settle down and stop laughing. I suddenly realize I have no idea what to do next. Where do I put my hands? Am I supposed to start it? I don't know anything.

So I start listing things I do know. I know this will be my first kiss. I know I've liked Caleb for as long as we've been friends. I know that I have to do this. I know that we both love Darude's Sandstorm. I know both of our parents make us go to mass on Sundays. I know he loves to skateboard. I know he likes to watch hockey. I know that he doesn't care about this kiss. I know I do. I know this might change everything. I know that he likes someone. I know I don't know who it is. I know if it is not me, I will be upset. I know I have to kiss someone I like, who might not like me.

"Are you ready?" He whispers, though the classroom is loud enough that no one could hear. Maybe he's trying to be gentle, or maybe he's just as nervous as I am.

I nod. "Yes." I decide I have to be the first one, the dare is mine, after all. So I tenderly lean up on my toes, toward his mouth. I pretend I know what I'm doing. I pretend it won't be awkward. I lean up and close my eyes. Our lips meet. They're soft but capped, and I catch a faint whiff of cologne. Not unpleasant. I settle my lips on his bottom lip, hoping that is where they are supposed to be. I hold the moment for a heartbeat, then pull back, quickly turn out of the closet, and march back to my seat where Kristina and David are waiting.

"Did you guys do it?" Kristina asked me all too knowing, and wanting the details.

"Yes," I mumble, not daring to look at her. My cheeks are on fire, my stomach twisting. Did I enjoy it? Did I want to do it again? Does it even matter if he doesn't care?

I hear the seat in front of me scrape back.

David leans forward with a smirk. "Okay, how was it?"

Caleb shrugs, trying to look casual. "It was good."

My heart skips a beat, though I force myself to act nonchalant. What does that even mean? It was good? My hands are still trembling slightly, and warmth still creeps across my cheeks.

Mrs. Dahl claps her hands. “Alright, class, bring up your journals to be graded. I will return them next week when we start the Matthews Gospels. Everyone has a wonderful weekend.”

As Kristina and I start packing up our things, I sneak a glance at Caleb. He’s still leaning back in his chair, chatting with David, but there’s a small, almost imperceptible smile on his lips. Somehow, that tiny smile makes the butterflies in my stomach feel a little lighter.